Master of Business Adaptation



For generations of students and professionals, a master in business administration has been an assured path to the corner office. Today, as businesses confront sweeping changes in the operating landscape and students face the realities of a tough job market, management education stands at a crossroads, and the role of a business school is being redefined. This is the focus of the *Business Today*–MDRA Best B-Schools 2026-27 edition that evaluates the performance of 277 participating management institutes across India.

Management education, which goes back to as early as 1819, has evolved continuously. From the manufacturing and operations-focused programmes of earlier decades to the technology and financial-services-linked curriculum of recent years, change has been constant. As Professor Bharat Bhasker, Director, IIM, Ahmedabad, which has once again emerged as India's top business school, puts it, "the technological platform on which business operates keeps transforming, but business problems themselves stay largely similar."

With the widespread use of artificial intelligence (AI) nowadays, the business landscape is reshaping the format of the traditional MBA degree. As Madan Pillutla, Dean and Professor of Organisational Behaviour, Indian School of Business, puts it, the future of management education could move towards a more flexible, personalised model, where professionals acquire specific capabilities when they need them, rather than following a fixed learning journey.

It is this trend that *Krishna Gopalan* examines in the cover story on how global and Indian business schools are rethinking their MBA programmes amid declining applications, rising costs, and changing employer expectations. While some US and UK schools have discontinued two-year full-time MBAs, Indian institutes, including the IIMs, are promoting one-year executive programmes. The overall trend points towards a more flexible and skills-based management education.

A similar shift is also visible in how employers hire management graduates. *Mamta Sharma* describes how placements, by far the most crucial outcome for students, are changing, with companies becoming more selective and prioritising hires who can solve problems. The placement data from the study shows that hiring at India's Top 25 B-schools declined, while business schools ranked 51–75, saw an increase in the placement rate. This suggests that employers are now hiring for specific capabilities.

This is precisely why the *BT* ranking of the best business schools continues to matter. For students planning to acquire a management education, choosing a business school is the most important decision to build a career.

For institutions, building business leaders who can innovate and solve complex problems will be critical.

The MBA will still matter as long as it trains students to adapt and evolve.



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